

THINGS UNSEEN

A novella about everything I hate. Haven't published the last 30-ish pages yet, but they're coming.

By Lizard

My employers said a study would take place, but not much more than that. *Who's studying who?* I thought at the time. Were they watching me in some bizarre experiment that would follow my life and debrief my family with moral lessons? Or was I doing work as usual? You could never be sure with big companies. Science was secretive, and without a doctorate, jobs were sparse— besides grunt work contracts like mine. Good researchers asked others to collect samples for them. They spent most days holed up in their labs, rotting away.

Right. Who *was* studying who? From the file I received, I was to visit a remote mountain range about twelve hours from my lab of origin. My dwellings would consist of a small, camouflaged hut, and the nearby village would provide me with aid. It occurred to me that my employers had nobody more qualified; this did seem like an important project. Leafing through the attached documents, I noticed several redactions.

“_____ must not be observed directly.” Apparently, I wasn't allowed to look the subject in the eye; a sort of modern Medusa, I gathered. Biological weaponry? Long-range poison? Supernatural somethings? Even entertaining the thought felt surreal. If my employers were any less legitimate, and thank goodness they were, I might have questioned it more... But I didn't. Pretty pennies bought soup, and soup tasted the same either way, whether the pennies came from a dead man's corpse or a creature's suffering.

Reading on, this creature hunted with claws and rudimentary tools, fished in the streams below its cave, and climbed faster than a mountain goat...? It slept from the hours of 3 AM to 9 AM, then took another rest in the evening. Hunting trips occurred sporadically, timing inconclusive. I had to establish my own trends in that regard. Its behaviours weren't described in detail, but the telltale signs— tentative double spaces, more redactions— implied aggression. I'd worked with bad files before. I knew what flew red.

Although the briefing papers screamed “monster” without using the word itself, I couldn’t exactly turn the job down. My financial situation and less-than-ideal employment contract wouldn’t let me. Monstrosity, I told myself in consolation, meant nothing. Many civilised groups were deemed savage, put down and killed by their observers for no reason other than arbitrary difference; a backwards mess, like much of the world.

If anyone understood the true merit (none) of name and degree, it was me. Only I could see this through. Scrawling my name on the sanitised white sheet, streaking across the thing like a developer on clean land, I signed myself away for yet another job. Sixty dollars an hour for six months would pay not only my rent, but my family’s outstanding debts. It’s much less like dealing with the devil when the devil helps you out.

Anyway, I began my journey after a short period of travel by plane. The locals, living in farms and villages at high altitudes, were tight-knit like ordinary country folk. Not sure what else I expected. They met me with stares at first, then ignored me altogether after I began asking about the mysterious creature. Weapons were hung over most fireplaces, and inside the homes I visited; this seemed to be an ordinary custom. Again, I wasn’t here on tourist business, nor was I here to conduct cultural studies, so I accepted their behaviour for the most part. Negative comments regarding my company of origin—“you crooks, you dirty *****”—also came by. Those were fun.

Gathering provisions proved easy. Besides the rations in my pack, I also purchased preserves, hardtack, and dried fish from a hunter’s hut. As the only villager who supported my cause, he lent me two spears as well, despite my active refusal. While not explicitly prohibited in my regulations, accepting weapons felt wrong. Before I left him, he reminded me to keep my wits high and my mind strung tight... Whatever that meant. Sick from travel and exhausted, I only replied, “yes”, then went on my way.

Scaling the mountain was the next hell I faced. Despite the gear at my disposal and two months of training prior to the climb, I spent two days, and four hours climbing from the uppermost human settlement. I know the exact figures because my watch, given to me for this study specifically, said so. And added that my heartbeat was too high. Great.

What met me after much sweat, frustration, and pain was a clever structure at the summit. Camouflaged as a rock, I barely noticed its protrusion at first. The outer surface had no windows besides hard, mesh-like patches every few feet, and as I ran my hands along its surface, I felt what seemed like a crack. This crack became a larger crack, then a door once my fingernails wedged themselves in, and opened to my new base. I peeked in, frowned, and peeked back out. Two days' work for *that*? Maybe I wasn't cut out for wilderness survival. Or science at all. My dedication was just as well transferable to, say, a fast food job. Luck brought me here, and luck would take me away.

Arms crossed, I surveyed the outdoor fruits of my pain... Which were much prettier. Lightly snow-capped peaks, cut messily like broken spears, made way for one another in a mountainous lattice, and even further past, I could make out grassy plains before the tree line. Streams, likely those described in the briefing, flowed into its verdance like white ribbons. Everything breathed in such harmony that the scene could have been a painting— *should* have been one, if only artists loved nature as much as they professed to. So high, so full of the world that my lungs burnt, I tipped my head to a cloudless sky.

The altitude sickness packs in my pocket were far away, out of sight and mind, as I connected with the great wide blue. Living here for six months straight would dampen my enthusiasm, I knew, but I would keep this first success in my pocket like a photograph. It was a real shame that my employers disallowed taking pictures for personal use. Nobody in the world but me, here, would ever understand how I felt.

Directly across from my new base was another peak, close enough to hit the other on its nose. From my geographical knowledge, they were still part of the same mountain, despite the valley between us that I was *adamant* on not staring at. Any longer than a second and my legs would grow weak. Leafing through my pocketbook of notes, I read, “Opposite of rock -> creature’s cave. On ledge?”. Through my small, cracked pair of binoculars— I had better equipment that I planned to unpack after setting up camp— I spied what seemed like a dark spot on the opposite mountainside. On 20X zoom, though, it might have been anything. I traded my curiosity for truth and ignored it.

Truth alone was a rare commodity; the *current* truth being that my legs were numb and the wind would not stop battering my jacket. And my budget hurt. Sporting cheap clothing, just enough food to save me from starvation, and more scientific equipment than brainpower, I forced my body upright and entered the rock-hut; a small, modular thing that didn’t really look finished. There were no rooms or foreseeable exits besides the front door, and the ceiling was so low I had to duck. One chair, a foldable table, two pillows but no sleeping bag, and what looked like a chamber pot greeted me. The entire space smelled of plastic and incipient cancer. I sat cross-legged on its tarped floor.

The job, as pitched, was to observe a mysterious creature that I couldn’t even look in the eye. Felt awfully like a joke, but who was I to protest? The consequences of breaching this rule were not explained besides immediate termination, whether that be from the company or life altogether. With high-powered imaging technology and specialised night vision binoculars, my employers advised me to keep time and note any anomalies in the creature’s schedule. Not difficult, per se. Just tedious.

Directly viewing the opposite mountainside was only permitted during its sleeping hours. Once a week, they recommended I visit its cave; first to plant a remote camera, then to

scour the area for potentially useful fur samples. During the first phase of research, though, I didn't want any risks. Only careful, careful data collection. For now I would wait as a shadow in my hut, oddly elated but equally as terrified, and let time pass. I organised my self-boiling pot, sleeping corner, and some simple equipment. Just like home. Home, sweet mountain.

While dinner, a fortified sludge, combined with cold water in one of my bowls, I scribbled down some preemptive notes. How did the creature look? How did it go about life with whatever semblance of intelligence it possessed? Who, once again, was studying who? Unanswered questions stole my mind as I spooned sludge. My joints had already started to ache from the cramped space, but I felt better than ever. *Banana*, I wrote without thinking. Some stupid nutritionist from my company had decided that sweet dinner was a good idea. Several drops, on purpose or otherwise, fell on the floor.

Horrible food aside, I wanted to prove myself to them. They obviously believed in my skills. I got it into my head that the apex of scientific greatness was only inches away from my fingers, thin and brittle as a needle, and if I were to find something incredible here, then maybe my contract would terminate for reasons *other* than disobedience. In the past, I'd conducted clinical trials on rats and fished the oceans on industrial trawlers; all for work. Hell, I'd braved a tornado and come out alive, to their chagrin... But those jobs were ants beside this half-year project. Here, I was their star. Or their sacrifice. Or both.

The first evening, around 11 PM, I opened a new package of rations— banana cereal, I cursed silently— and set up my observer's station. Most of the camouflaged hut, about half, was devoted to storing equipment. I sat between two tripods and a large mounted telescope, wiggling my binoculars around so that they would fit in a mesh-covered peephole. The odds of direct eye contact were minimal, this way; next to none. I was quite convinced of my safety. Mostly moving equipment, adjusting sharpness and whatnot, I placed the camera

system outside under a grey tarp. Only the tip of its lens peeked through. This was a test run, but if things went badly here, they would go even worse when I encountered my subject.

I'd never used such expensive technology in my entire life. The budget logs tacked onto my briefing, which were more transparent than the study itself, indicated that I would pay at least \$20 000 if anything broke. About 10% of that, thinking logically, went to the camera system and binoculars... And about 5% of that, quite honestly, was my bank account's balance. If I ruined anything, it'd be -

No. Real life couldn't touch me *here*. Not atop a mountain, so alone that my own breaths were entertainment. I watched them condense on the wall and listened to the vibrations of my chest. How wondrous was the human body, I thought; how soft. And how strange, beneath all its crossed wires. I began my test run shortly afterwards.

The binoculars were high-powered, hands-free, and worked like a charm in the dark. At the 30X function I could watch the creature's home in all its glory, and after some shifting I found a sweet spot. What appeared to be the creature's cave was camouflaged by scrub and boulders, all tinted green by my lenses, and I could just barely make out the entrance; wide, a dark, swampy colour that meant black. A spray of tendrils and determined plants covered the nearby ledge, but stopped further down as if snipped.

Maximising my zoom, I skimmed past striped bands of rock and snow. At this level, not even an ant would pass unnoticed. To my joy I thought, *equipment tests successful*. I mostly ignored the particular arrangement of bushes and dried flowers strewn about, which I assumed were useless debris. If I'd known any better, they might have been decorations; territory markings, put scientifically.

Suddenly, before I could continue exploring, a black mass covered my field of view. I zoomed in again, meaning to reset the binoculars, but nothing changed. I switched out to about 40X, lost track of the cave, and swore at myself. Once my lenses finally refocused on the original point of observation, I almost fell back at what I saw.

The same black mass as before, blurred as if someone had cut a hole in space, came into view. It had shape, from what I could gather, but a fur-like substance covered all notable appendages or eyes. This was my subject. It had to be. Reciting the terms and conditions of my contract like a prayer, I unstrapped the binoculars and gathered myself. My hands were shaking, too cold to function, and I couldn't stop the dread that shook me in shivers; the only tangible thing besides the creature and myself. If I thought about it hard enough, I was the only human for miles around. I existed in a horror-movie vacuum and, whether it be the project or my own mind that did me in, I would inevitably die. Never mind, too dramatic.

Thump. Was that my heartbeat or a piece of stupid equipment? I couldn't tell. *Thump.* I had to get working at *some* point. Dwelling on fear was counterproductive, altogether unscientific, and the one thing I'd realistically die from. The thing didn't have any visible eyes... I would be just fine. I couldn't even look it in the face, given the mop of static fuzz around its body. Work made money. Money made science. Science made the world go round.

With only a nervous rhythm— which I'd decided was my heart— to keep me company, I snapped the binoculars back on. Made quicker and stronger by muscle memory, I found my target immediately. It had moved in the time I spent away, slightly closer to its cave now. Tall, maybe eight feet on the hind paws (claws?). Likely two legged, but debatably so; more of a cloud than a being. Shifting my head to the side, I noticed a limp, brown-grey form trailing behind the creature's void. It had been hidden by the bushes before, and blended in with the rock even now, but appeared distinctly separate.

An elk, maybe? Some sort of large, hooved prey animal, I assumed. Dark, half-dried blood smeared the ground as the creature struggled with its meal, shuffling around like a penguin, before dragging the dead animal into the darkness of its cave. By then, black fur and black shadow were indistinguishable.

I waited for another minute. No movement. Two minutes. No movement besides a slight shift in the area, and that might have been my own breath fogging the peephole. My legs grew tired from crouching, feet half-frozen already, but it took another hour of thump-thumps and quiet anticipation before I removed my binoculars and warmed myself with a heat pack. The observation period was over. No more until later.

As my body closed around the warmth, wind began to whistle outside. It was a mournful swirling that ebbed and flowed like liquid sound. I'd felt godly at that moment. Now, I just felt lonely. Drained, as if on a comedown from some hard drug. Humans loved seeking the hidden, that I knew— but for the first time, I understood why. Seeing what did not want to be seen was powerful and new; perverted, almost, like tame voyeurism.

The Loch Ness Monster, Bigfoot, Yetis; they satisfied our urges, real or not. Finally it was as if I'd found my own monster, the key to a sandbox where anything I said and did would become true. *This* was no bear. No mountain lion. No man. This, I thought excitedly, was a researcher's thesis paper. An animal named after them.

Flipping through my preliminary notes, I popped the cap off a pen and set out to record the last twelve-or-so minutes. 12 AM, 6th of...? Tuesday. Right. Only 181 days left of this stuff. As per my training, I began with a summary of the equipment— just binoculars today, nothing nice— and procedure, which was simple. That part, I breezed through. Next, I drew a rudimentary sketch of the subject and laughed at myself for a few minutes. I'd destroyed the inkwell by scribbling all over in black.

For the most important bit, I conducted some “behavioural analysis” to gauge hostility. I settled on the solitary predator classification, and left their aggression number unknown. The blank space was unsettling in the back of my mind, so I later wrote ‘2’ as a filler. Carnivorous diet, et cetera... What else? Likely an ambush hunter. Given its coloration and quiet nature, I probably wasn’t far off the mark. Like most others, I made the preliminary assumption that it went after large meals once a week, but further testing was required to determine exactly how long it could survive without food. That elk was *large*. Over half a ton, no doubt, and female too, which made the catch even rarer.

Back in the day, before I signed myself away to jobs and endless travel, I watched nature documentaries for fun. I had a genuine interest in science, or so I thought. Sights like these came only under the stars. The idea of discovering a new species— that there *were* new species to discover in this century— was almost surreal. Like a monster under my bed, the creature sat and waited for its big break; nightmarishly close, always seconds from turning, locking eyes with me.

I shivered. Whether the temperature had gotten colder or my body had gotten nervous, I didn’t know. The portable thermostat, hung on a hook I’d nailed to the inside of the hut, read a constant 5 degrees Celsius... and that was with insulation. Evidently, my company hadn’t thought about anything besides expensive equipment and thick instructions. Incredible as the odour-beating chamber pot professed itself to be, I still dumped my business off the mountain like any old caveman. I still bundled myself in branded blankets and prayed that the wind wouldn’t blow my dreams away. Or worse, my soul.

The funny thing about souls, I thought while resetting my equipment for the next morning, was that they existed only in concept. Almost as nebulous as the creature, souls had no purpose beyond literary devices. Souls were altogether unscientific. Despite this, I liked

thinking about them. I liked thinking that mine rested somewhere in my chest, dancing with my beating heart, and held all the nice memories my brain hadn't the bandwidth to keep.

After placing the binoculars back into their case, my wristwatch flashed 2 AM. About six hours until sunrise, my prescribed waking time. I half-shuffled, half-crawled from the hut with a patterned tarp and infrared camera in tow, vowing to make up for my lost sleep later (and ensuring that future data collection was less involved). It was fun to sit stiffly all night, but I knew I wouldn't last a month that way. The "auto-record" function on the camera existed for a reason, and would map everything right to my little screen inside.

Skittering back, I felt the wind lash at my sweater, tearing the thing apart. By the time I'd returned, about an hour later on account of technical issues, my hands had gone numb. I considered writing "preliminary hypothermia" in my notes until I remembered that one day, if I survived, they would all be submitted to higher management. Higher management didn't understand jokes. They likely didn't understand any terrestrial language, given their inhumane treatment of employees. Another bad joke.

It was still difficult to rationalise *why* these corporate aliens wanted such in-depth research. If they needed medicine, DNA, or a bioweapon compound, a week or two would do the trick. Just enough to collect samples, formulate some pages of notes, and await further testing elsewhere. Instructing me to remain prudent, survive six months in the wilderness, and look away if the creature ever met my eyes; well, that meant high expectations and lucrative rewards. Evidently my company knew *something* about its characteristics, or they'd never have formulated a briefing sheet. What more did they want?

I stopped myself there. Thinking about it had no merit. Money was money, and what little my family received was good enough. Relative to most corporate dogs, I was quite alright—chancing a major discovery, getting downtime, and travelling so often too.

Satisfied with this reconciliation, I made myself breakfast; instant, pre-hydrated oatmeal with freeze-dried banana chunks in the mix. The bananas were alright, if not a bit tasteless, and I'd already gotten used to the clouds of stench that wafted through the hut. I narrowly avoided fumigating myself by opening the door, letting the poison escape, and slamming it shut. Did these nutritionists know how to formulate *anything* without bananas?

There were about six hours until my subject was projected to emerge next. Currently, I sat right in its naptime— and nothing much could happen then, besides setup. Sitting alone with my thoughts wasn't exactly appealing, so I fished some cards from my pack in the corner and began a game of Solitaire. The setting-up process was arduous, especially with cold hands, but I managed, all the while thinking about my next visit to the village. I had enough rations for another month. The trip would only be for fun; to save my sanity and hopefully, if all went well, connect me with knowledgeable residents who knew more about the creature than my company.

Damn it. What a bad deal. See, the worst thing about Solitaire was that you *could* lose. Losing against myself— my own mind— made me feel stupid, consoled only by solitude and the imminent redealing. I shuffled my cards again, laying them down without a reserve deck, and played until my eyes started to burn. 4 AM, said the watch in flashing digital script. Then 4:30, then 5:00, then the numbers made no sense. By then I knew it was time to stop. If I quit, I'd be up in time for 10 AM at least.

At the back of my notebook, I scribbled one last sketch; the creature again this time, but more carefully rendered so as to catch the limbs hiding under its fur, its bear-like snout with short, pointed teeth, and the trail of blood behind. Looked like a real monster.. Before I could remind myself that the whole point of this job, really, was to conduct research and not fear, I fell asleep, notebook splayed out beside me. My dreams came in painful fits.

Two weeks passed. It was mostly an uneventful period marked by little, boring successes like setting up my emergency comms system (“Hello, World”) and enabling the audio function on the camouflaged camera. Apart from technological progress, I’d gotten into the ebb and flow of solitary living. I knew how to keep myself entertained on slow days with songs, stories, sketches, and brand new variants of Solitaire. Sickness and stomach problems had escaped me thus far, and the fortified banana cereal was *seriously* nutritious. The views were stellar too. Felt a bit like a vacation, if I ignored my numb fingertips and ears... And nose, and cheeks. With most jobs, you couldn’t expect healthy bowel movements, let alone fresh air like this.

As for the creature, I managed a rudimentary schedule. Long-term, seasonal patterns couldn’t be determined just yet, but it stuck to strict rules every day— and for that I was thankful. Matching my briefing papers, it always slept from 3-9 AM. For the past two Fridays in a row, it had gone out to hunt at 10 PM, returning with smaller catches than first observed; a brace of shrews and an unassuming partridge. The elk was long-term sustenance if kept properly. The others, just snacks. I still hadn’t gotten a good glimpse of its face besides the black mass from my first sighting, but then again, I wasn’t allowed to.

Once in a while, the creature exhibited surprisingly dextrous skills. Opposable thumbs? It would shuffle around, moving rocks to and fro during active hours, even smearing snow over nearby bloodstains. The process reminded me of male birds-of-paradise and their spotless dance floors... Only without the mating bit. My subject’s work served no demonstrable benefit, but quite like humans and their quirks, this was a sign of intelligence.

I thought about the redactions often. I thought about them in conjunction with what I’d found so far. Quite like my first judgement, I got the sense of a misunderstood beast. The thing was trying to manage as best as it could, like some old man trapped in a prison. It didn’t

scare me anymore. We weren't too different from each other, anyway; both lonely mountain dwellers with set schedules. I liked watching it emerge, groggy and slow, an hour or two after sunrise— then replaying the footage of its re-entrance after an excursion.

On that note, the creature's so-called excursions happened pretty often. I'd counted eight so far. During these, the creature would leave home at an odd hour and return empty-handed but obviously happier, with a spring in its step. My only viable theory was that it took walks; little hikes through the hills and streams, stopping by pretty patches of bejewelled snow, letting its fur soak in sunbeams. Just a theory, though. And likely wrong. There was no merit in boosting happiness beyond the baseline, wasting precious hours that would be better devoted to hunting.

Besides the aforementioned idiosyncrasies like trips and redecoration, I noticed one other thing. This one was the strangest, for sure. It happened about one and a half weeks in, if I'd noted the event correctly; right before sunset. My outdoor camera started firing, blasting notifications on the connected screen, and I put down my dinner to watch the live feed. Bananas could wait. While the steaming pile of mush grew cold, I settled down with a blanket and heat pack, feeling the same regular, expected excitement as usual. What would I see today? An unexpected hunt?

Thanks to the auto-track feature I'd coded in earlier, the camera focused on what was causing such a stir; not the mouth of the cave but a steep dropoff some metres away. As usual, a familiar form appeared. I expected no one else. Starkly black against the precipice, my subject stood just inches from death. Little bits of displaced snow tumbled off, pebbles too, as it swayed back and forth like a trancing monk.

Reasonably, I assumed that there was prey further down. The creature probably meant to climb, but given the distance, watched from afar. Cats did that— wanting but never taking

unless it served them well. I scribbled down my notes in traditional form, as usual, and thought myself a real good scientist. Maybe this would be my big break, somehow; the behaviour that everyone wanted me to document. After noticing movement in its fur, perhaps an opening mouth, I turned up the camera's audio sensitivity and let my speakers run. Might have been a mating call or a more general communication tactic.

Now, what I heard was unlike *any* other animal's cry. Elks let out throaty screeches that sounded terrifying in their own right; wolves stole the timbre of the moon; birds sang like sirens when desperate; but this? This rumbled through my spine like a whale-song, vibrations shaking me from my shoddy speakers and coming in echoes through the tent, played both outside and inside. It was a deep, low, mourning noise— guttural and almost demonic, if I believed in demons at all. On second thought, maybe closer to human. The sound of wartorn countries and mothers going hoarse over dead children. My subject's call left palpable grief in its wake, and I starved in the silence that followed.

The last of my scientific mind, shell-shocked from whatever I'd just heard, asked a tentative, "Why?" But my heuristic hemispheres shushed it right after. Flickering, the camera panned back to the cave as the creature, having gone eerily quiet, moved away from its cliff. No return message came. No response from kin, nothing from foe; only loneliness.

It was more so meant to convey emotion than anything, I decided— and also transcribed in small, light print, hesitant enough to be erased if I changed my mind. Animals could feel. Even rats showed empathy, though rudimentarily. I felt it right to acknowledge that truth. Here I was, like a dead god's cleric scrawling down their memory, as I had been the only observer of their divine miracle.

Over the course of my two stationed weeks, the previous incident stood out most. Other than that and a decent behavioural profile, I had nothing groundbreaking. My

emergency comms overseers, likely grunt workers like me, replied to my inquiries with neutral language and stale encouragement. When I raised the horrible moan, scream, whatever it was, they promised to relay my findings as soon as possible and nothing more. They also reminded me that the channel was for *emergencies*, not excited reports. Data would be analysed and collated after six months to paint a more holistic picture of the situation, one overseer said. Any present breakthroughs would need to stay on hold.

My subject and I weren't too different from one another. Both lonely hearts at high altitudes sitting and sleeping our days away. The difference was, I had Solitaire and humanity. What did the creature live for, besides walks and survival? Not propagation, no; there were no members of its species anywhere, and I'd never even heard of whatever it was. Evolution had left it in the dust, hoping and praying for something I couldn't understand.

Anyway, my sketches had gotten pretty good. What features I couldn't see were easy to construct from its basic anatomy— skull shape, head size, the slightest hint of a snout peeking out— and I sharpened some of the photographs I'd taken to get a better look. During breakfast and dinnertime, when I had nothing more important to do, I either worked with my pen or my brain; drawing or cards. One week of endless Solitaire, every variant attempted and beaten, was all it took for me to prioritise the pen.

My sketch from the morning of the 22nd was half-finished. Looking back, it was the only journal page that had no lower body or shading; wrapped up in a hurry, ink all smudged. The 22nd shocked me, I remember— because for the first time in my entire contract, I'd gotten clear instructions. That day my comms system beeped like hell, kept ringing off the hook, until I left the sketch and picked up the responder like a phone. In essence it was cuboid and black, more of a walkie-talkie, but I'd never used those old things before. And my company never sent voice messages unless they were serious. If luck was on my side, we

would speak directly for the first time too. Felt like I hadn't talked to a human being in centuries, closer to the so-called "monster" than anyone of my species. Close enough, almost, to give the thing a name and invite it in.

9:05 AM, I noted. Right before my first scheduled observation period. It likely wouldn't happen today, given the snowstorm half-blowing my walls down. The camera needed retrieving, though, and I was almost annoyed that my company had decided to bother me *right* before the trip. They didn't know anything about struggle. Where was my paycheque, by the way? Did I agree on bi-weekly rates?

"Hello," a voice crackled from the other end of the comms box. Some androgynous, stuffy prick clearly in a better place than me. Cubicle, no doubt.

"Congratulations on your progress. Your data, even two weeks in, has been an *invaluable* asset to ongoing research. It is necessary that you take more of a hands-on role in the coming months, as we will also need samples: Fur samples, faecal matter, urine, and any transportable secretions. These may be stored in ice or given to a trusted member of the nearby settlement. We suggest you use the portable tent for intimate observation. It should be underneath the rightmost floorboard by the entrance, as detailed in your briefing. Ah, right... And remember your most important rule; if the creature turns to look at you, shut your eyes *immediately*. Failure to do so will result in termination. Good luck!"

I raised my voice and tried to speak several times, once a "Thank you...?" and then a "I'm not just ready for...", but the speaker went on. By then, I'd realised it was automated, and felt stupid to think that I was special enough for one-on-one conversation. Their message played choppily, buffering and rewinding at crucial parts, but I got the general gist. They wanted me to sneak into the subject's cave, hopefully camp there overnight, and steal. Steal like a colonist. Like a monster hunter.

The intricacies of intimate research weren't new to me. I'd done some work for documentary films. Patience was key, see. You could wait for hours, days even, in a spindly tree until two target animals began mating or doing whatever the videographers thought was relevant. Nature took her sweet time, never bending to the whims of humanity, no matter how badly they needed a shot.

Some part of me was worried about the whole up-close thing. Sternly, the voice message reminded me that my original terms and conditions remained— no eye contact, no touch, the usual— which almost directly contradicted my orders to come closer. If any small details went awry, I would find myself staring straight into the mouth of a cave *and* a potentially dangerous animal. My company was feeding me to the beasts, here. I needed time to form a schedule, ensure I wouldn't ever run into it, practise my stealthiness... But I had just shy of six months left. Five and some was more than enough. There were about twenty plastic baggies in my pack, pre-sealed and tagged for samples. I counted. So long as I kept up the good work, they'd be filled and gone by next month.

Head mostly empty, I watched my fuzzy reflection dance and warp in the hut's plastic window. There were no mirrors here; I saw more of my subject than myself. If I looked horrible and gaunt, wasting away despite the banana mush's best attempts, nobody existed to tell the truth. Nobody for miles and miles of empty peaks. If I died all of a sudden, which I hoped wouldn't be the case (but you never know), nobody existed to stroke my hand and deliver me home. Sorry, family.

Was science inherently morbid? Was that why death always haunted my mind? I loved watching bleeding, limp animals enter the creature's cage. Its muscles contracted to drag them along silently, shortening and lengthening under a void of fur. I'd convinced myself this appreciation was only scientific, but maybe there was something else; a loss of

agency revived through observation, and an utter loss of myself as a being in society; reversion to primitivism, whether I wanted it or not. I told myself I'd visit the village again, hopefully tomorrow, and scatter all these thoughts on the wind. I needed more salted fish, anyway, and more information on the creature before I risked my life for the corporate machine. A two day long hike wouldn't be too bad. Especially if it brought some crucial bit of human sanity back to me.

After one day of preparation, my hiking pack was stuffed to the brim and above with a sleeping bag, some dehydrated "banana bread", an insulated water bottle, rope, and other necessities that I probably wouldn't use. If I kept on route and zipped my parka tight, I'd survive without hypothermia to show for it. The way down was full of easy zigzags and minimal climbing. I only took a short rest, anchoring my sleeping bag to the flattest platform I could find and zipping myself tight. All around, the snow felt almost warm, and I woke with a soft dusting over my belongings. No snowslides, no problems. No frostbite, no deaths in sleep, even less problems. Woohoo.

Sometimes I'd take breaks to thaw myself, wincing as my fingers and toes burnt awake, but I kept a steady pace and saw brown soon enough. Spilling from either side of the mountainside streams that I'd been following were scrubby, yellowish-green and white hills with spots of evergreens here and there. Above their sleepy sprawl, maybe a kilometre or so off, I saw the flat roofs I'd passed by last month; my last stop before complete and utter isolation. They looked the same as before. Constant but undeniably alive, sporting blurry splashes of colour— on the doors, mainly, which were painted blue and red.

By the time I arrived, I was both hungry and tired. *Just* conscious enough to be happy I hadn't run into anything on my way down. An old woman hanging her clothes out to dry stared at me, shook her head, and went back to work. The village stood on a rocky incline,

and as I made my way up the path that wound around each settlement, I met another suspicious-looking resident. I'd seen him earlier, I swore. He gave me the same stare as before, shooting daggers through his hooded lids. Hostility, but with added recognition. Would be nice, I thought bitterly, if someone here would *talk*.

To my luck, I ran into the hunter who had offered me two spears. He proposed a goat this time, but I graciously declined and instead visited his small, rickety home a ways away from the rest. Finding it hard to string words together, I let him talk, focusing on how his mouth moved; his eyebrows; the fluidity with which he poured bitter tea and downed it, all the while alert. I felt stupid. Crazy, maybe. Even the simplest things made me self-conscious, by no fault of his. Going from complete emptiness to complete judgement was jarring. Despite my awkwardness, he carried on just the same. I told him about the research project, from what I was allowed to disclose, and lapsed into a nice rhythm of diary recollections. I mentioned my subject's strange behaviours, hunting patterns, and how I was to enact the next phase very soon.

At this, he let out a drawn-out sigh. "The village does not want you to approach it," he said— or at least, from what I gathered. Our dialects weren't exactly compatible, but I was too nervous to ask for a repeat. After asking about the villagers' apprehension, he insulted both my company and my research. Honestly, I didn't mind his frankness. He appreciated me as a person, corporate shell as I was, but refused to respect anything else. It took some considerable prying before he gave me more information.

Around midday, after I'd helped him skin some hares and feed the skinny-looking goats in his yard, the hunter sat me down again and told stories.

The first story of three was an old myth beyond scientific reach. According to him, village life had always been peaceful. That was, before the 'demon' came. By demon, I

assumed he meant my subject, and by breaking the peace, he meant stealing livestock and purportedly children. By common religious beliefs, this shattered peace was divine retribution for another, worse crime wrought on the mountains and waters— and nobody could defeat nor capture its purveyor, for it was so strong and sneaky, stitched together from pure darkness, that it always escaped.

Next, the hunter segued into his second story. This time, it was about my company. His theory, he said, was that their activities in the nearby valleys had stirred up such godly anger. From what I knew, they'd started a little mining enterprise up the way, but I came from the opposite direction and paid no mind to whatever else was going on. Multinationals took part in a variety of odd things, often to the environment's detriment. Such was the course of life. I had no shits left to give about their monopolies. Anyway, it wasn't scientifically possible that the creature appeared out of thin air, so I told the hunter just that. He stared at me and frowned a pitiful frown that said, "I respected you once. Now, I don't."

Before concluding my visit, I asked a few more questions; namely, about when the creature had arrived in the area and how exactly it "abducted" villagers. With luck, I'd learn a bit more about its weaponous gaze and investigate a possible connection between its behaviours and the mining. Logically, it made sense that habitat-deprived beings would migrate elsewhere and look to settlements for prey, but I wasn't about to call my company and explain this. I knew nothing of their motivations.

The hunter went on with another story. One little boy who had seen the creature and faced its wrath, so to speak, went blind immediately afterwards. He babbled strange words to himself and sat in the darkness, rocking back and forth, as if possessed. The village, of course, concluded that he had been possessed by some darker force and cast him out to die. As for the process of abduction, the hunter seemed well-versed. Any household without

weapons and locks on their doors would eventually fall victim. Once a month or so, the creature— demon, as he said— would come down and check for vulnerable settlements. If none existed, it would turn its eyes to livestock. Maybe some of those walks I'd recorded were actually murderous romps...? Ah, maybe not.

Because this story was tinged with the same spirituality as before, I couldn't believe everything he said, but nodded along as well as I could. My compliance made him happier. He was wise by any and all metrics of wisdom... Just a bit old and senile. He went on for longer about my company, encouraging me to submit a report, and mentioned something about organised attacks in the works (on the demon, not the corporation). His manner of speaking was circular and hard to follow. Towards the end of our conversation, I wasn't sure which actions referred to which party. Demons were companies, creatures were demons, and humans were not absolved of monstrosity. I understood the last point, but the rest was all muddled up in my head. Once it began to throb, I settled in his goat-shed and slept there, reassured by his promises that the demon would not get me.

I wanted to ask more. I wanted to ask what "recently" meant, and whether "recently" coincided with my noted disappearances— or perhaps the extremely recent scream I'd heard; whether the villagers' efforts managed to injure it at all. Questions swirling like rocks in a whirlpool, I resolved to learn more after my headache had gone. Must have been that dehydrated banana pudding powder. Might have been the hunter's strong tea. Again, as was customary for me, I wondered what my company wanted. They were operating not too far away, were obviously hated by the village, and seemed adamant that I get samples of this so-called demon. The only thing they had in common with the hunter and his people was desire; a strong, burning pseudo-need to extract all they could and warp it into something understandable. Something monstrous, common, and easy to hate from afar.

I spent my night in the goat-shed. Oddly enough, sleep came easily, and morning light bathed my head in a soft white glow as I woke. Hours before, I'd dreamt of half-familiar faces and all-familiar creatures. My smart watch, which the hunter had marvelled at earlier, indicated I was behind schedule. Given this, I choked down my nausea and left the village with some souvenirs in tow; a jar of goat's milk, yellow pills meant to help with altitude sickness, and homemade sunglasses that supposedly worked better than my current pair. These all came from one or two villagers, of course. The rest, despite my prying, would not go beyond insulting my company and staring angrily at me.

So far as current plans went, I hoped to hike back up the mountain and retrieve the tent along with camera equipment, plastic baggies for samples, and a small black box for remote tracking. Less than two days later, in record time, I returned and did just that. No issues along the way, again. Nothing noteworthy. Warming myself inside the mountainside base with heat packs, I scribbled down basic observations of the village and what I could remember of its mythology. Hatred towards... A creature. Not a monster. Clearly a biological, not supernatural phenomenon. Assumption that... This creature's appearance around settlements is some sort of punishment for my company's actions. Likely explainable by migratory patterns... New habitat?

Capping my pen, I decided I might as well use the comms system and ask about the mining— or whatever was happening— further North. They had no reason to tell me, given that the work took place miles away (and they sank their grubby little claws into almost every corner of the world), but I thought it might be pertinent. Just in case our projects coincided. Also: If the villagers planned to harm my subject in any way, what role would I play in ensuring human and animal safety? Would I be impartial? And what would I do in the event of an unforeseen attack?

After about ten minutes of buzzing, a live human voice came from the speaker. Finally. My connection was horrid, and the voice on the other end kept buffering, but I held out patiently and stated my points until they went through properly. I started with a customary report, acknowledging their most recent message about samples, and asked for the comms worker's name. Felina, they said. Representative of our company. They spoke quickly, as if through a walkie talkie, using conventions like "10-9" and "Over".

When it came time, I asked about the potential ecological ramifications of the work up North and whether it may have affected my subject's hunting patterns. Clarifying further, I added that I was not all questioning my briefing form or the company. Simply curious, which was allowed. The villagers were hostile for reasons related to previous negative experiences with our coworkers— which I also felt the need to mention. They'd met before. Promises had been made and broken.

Felina coughed into her end of the microphone. Reading from what sounded like a script, she assured me that the villagers' support was not at all necessary to carry out research. Additionally, any disruptions to their lives and the creature itself were not relevant to me, therefore I mustn't worry about them. My job was simple and straightforward; observation for six months, sample collection, and some good photographs and videos. As mentioned, any meddling on my part was not welcome. She reminded me, in nicer words, that I was a menial employee with a special opportunity. Whatever happened to anyone besides myself meant nothing. Hell, I didn't need to know the science... And I probably wouldn't understand it with my run-of-the-mill degree in ecology. Ignoring Felina's condescension, I thanked her and sunk into another banana pudding.

Right as we were about to say our goodbyes, her with an "out" and me with a casual "see you", a strange thumping noise caught me off-guard. I dropped the comms device,

watching the light die from what I hoped was a temporary malfunction. The noise came intermittently, like the patter, patter, patter of rain, but heavier. I peeked out the plastic window to my side, still frustrated from my last conversation; frustrated enough to forget what fear meant. Damn that stupid company for putting me in an echo chamber shaped like a rock. Damn them for subjecting me to all this. And damn my own ego for letting them under the false pretence that they'd slap my name on a discovery.

All I could see out the window was pitch black. Nighttime had already fallen, that I knew, but stars still shone in the dark; they never *disappeared*. The noise grew louder. Before I put two and two together, a giant thump came from the ceiling. It sounded like something was on the roof. Climbing on the roof? Trying to destroy the roof? I assumed the worst. I knew this was the creature, but the fact that it had come so far and likely realised my rock-hut wasn't a rock... My heart caught in my chest. At the time, I couldn't breathe nor think rationally— only keep worrying, too caught up to switch on my outdoor camera and catch footage. That ceiling better hold up.

My subject weighed at least several hundred pounds. I could feel the plastic-adjacent material sag above my head, creaking and moaning in a horrible chorus of strain. Like a bear, I heard it chuff and growl, seemingly trying to figure out what to make of my home, and why the rock smelled or felt so strange. Animal curiosity, I reminded myself. Regular animal curiosity. So long as it didn't destroy the camera outside or fall through the ceiling, I'd survive. Might just have to relocate later.

All of a sudden, just as I'd gotten used to the regular beat of paws— claws, feet, whatever, the noise stopped. I pressed my ear against the door, and sure enough, *something* was happening. No more aggressive exploration. Here was the “monster under the bed” phenomenon. Here was my horror movie moment again, this time fully realised; a penance I

knew I'd eventually have to pay for my weeks of scientific pleasure. I heard it shuffle to the door, which was visible only by a little seam in the outer shell, and stand near my position. We were probably parallel to each other, whether the creature knew it or not, and I could feel, even from the safety of my base, the frostbitten sense of being watched. My eyes bore into the grey door. Its eyes did the same. This wasn't direct observation, by any means; I wasn't betraying the company in any way. But such closeness shot a primal course of adrenaline through my veins.

I remembered the hunter and his stories. All myths had a basis in truth. I saw myself as a martyr of the human race, killed for my faith in science and all things pure in a world that would not accept truth, then I saw myself as the sole survivor of some terrible apocalypse; me and the creature, obviously, just us— but the creature didn't count as human now, did it? In our brief moment of connection through the door, through the wall, it felt wrong to exclude them from common race. We were both intelligent beings searching, searching, searching for an out. Perhaps I was the weaker, digging where I knew I wouldn't find anything; looking for an escape in the wilds of the world, still tied down by my job. It felt like hours until the creature lumbered away. Its heavy footsteps grew quieter and quieter, then finally descended my portion of the mountain.

By the time all this had died out, I was shivering. My heartbeat thrummed in my ears, not too different from the first time I'd felt this way, and when I slowly peeled my hands from my face, I found little tooth-marks on them. Nervous biting to stay silent; to act like the stone that should have been inside a real boulder. I stared, disgusted, at the dribble of half-frozen saliva that connected my fist and mouth. This was stupid. So stupid. Yet another journal entry took shape as I fixed a package of dehydrated soup. Slowly but surely, the heat in my veins became blood, and I became myself again. I wrote this down.

Couldn't sleep on the strange fact of being discovered. Couldn't even close my eyes on it. I woke with a start, not sure whether I'd slept or just dreamt the whole thing, but some relief came over me at the sheer fact of my continued existence. Looking back on it, my subject probably hadn't realised anything special. Probably poked at a strange rock, lumbered off, and went back to whatever it did — which I knew well. Fifteen days in, I was practically an expert. Paging my comms network one last time before my departure, the message went as such: *One week of tent observation. Will return, either to village or base, to restock materials, food, etc. Communication unavailable during this period.*

They probably didn't care. I spoke into a heartless corporate void, but spoke nonetheless — teasing with subtle tugs, pouring my last dregs of hope down their throats. I still thought maybe I'd get somewhere with this horrible job and, you know, find *real* science. Make new science. Name a creature after myself, as if they'd ever give me ownership rights.

My dreams packed nicely into the tall green hiking bag I used to make village trips. Given the fact that I'd be away for about a week (give or take one day, since heading to the other rise in the mountain would take some time), I needed plenty of comforts to keep me busy. Cards for Solitaire, a first-aid kit, climbing gear, rations, the nature-friendly 'shower stick' I'd barely touched, and... Might as well take *that* too.

Underneath banana-scented ration wrappers, random bits of plastic that had fallen off cameras, and crumpled-up paper, I found, or rather discovered, an old charm from my family. Hadn't thought about it before. Hadn't even remembered bringing it. It was unassuming enough for me to absolve myself of guilt; a pea-green bracelet much too small for me, beads woven around twine like berries on vines.

My family didn't want me to die. They needed money. And because I was their sole source of income, they lent good luck charms in a transactional manner. I held the thing

close, then dangled it over my feet like a hostage before finally shoving it in my hiking backpack with all else. The truest test of luck would be whether it survived the week or not.

Family matters always gave me the shivers. Divorced from nuclear ideals and bonds, so devoted to biology that I couldn't see love as anything but an evolutionarily advantageous set of reactions, facing people like them was tough. I *loved* them, that I knew. I wanted to provide for them. But they sought my provisions and not much else— and for fear of letting myself slip, I would distance myself. Thinking of them then, before my camping trip, was one of the last breaches I allowed. When the bracelet tumbled into the bag, so did they.

Anyway, progress was on the horizon. Finding the tent neatly tucked inside a ground storage compartment, as Felina said, I huffed and puffed while I buzzed around, hauling it out before re-folding the entire tarp. My remaining packing consisted of shoving my provisions into the most space-effective lump possible, then thinking of better ways to do so and... Failing at those. I knew I had to hurry. It was 8 AM now, and if my hike took ten or eleven hours, then I'd only just arrive in time to set myself up. Any later and the creature might find me waddling across its territory like a free, pre-frozen meal.

Hiking down my own platform, then climbing to the ledge where the creature's cave sliced through the mountainside, was difficult. It needed more than just hiking prowess. I wore crampons and a helmet, brought an ice axe I'd found shoved along with the tent, and summoned every last bit of my training to scale the semi-steep ascent with no rope. They really wanted me dead, didn't they? Thankfully it wasn't the dead of winter— but still cold and residually snowy, dusting my coat and pants and settling down with uncomfortable dampness. At least my aerobic capacity had improved. Felt like I'd evolved.

I took minimal breaks and powered through the journey, only stopping to check the time for entertainment. 12 PM, 2 PM, 6:30 PM, and suddenly, after a particularly difficult

pass where my feet lost traction, I found myself there— arms scrabbling to reach the rock, hauling the rest of my body up and over, then peace. Solid, albeit slightly snowy, ground and *peace*. Peace, peace, peace. The same eerie silence I'd missed so well, stifled by the sound of my feet and ragged breaths up the mountainside. I was a few dozen metres away from the cave, but I wanted to set up camp somewhere hidden anyway. On the other side, ideally, where I knew the creature avoided. For whatever reason, it preferred to either scale its small strip of territory or visit the flats below. Everything else was respectfully ignored.

I arrived right before sunset. The snow, bathed in pinkish-orange light like a fantastical painting— a progressive rave of colour, shifting with clouds— caught me aback. My nose ached, my feet were cramping, and my stomach was half-concave, but I spent more time than I should have at the ledge. It was a strange view, angled such that I couldn't see the sun directly; only its effects, belonging to no one but the force of mountainside magic.

The going plan involved setting up camp, taking a long-awaited nap, then sneaking into the creature's cave during another scheduled absence. From 1 AM to 2:30 AM, if I woke before then. There I would plant a small recording device and camera and take several samples, leaving nothing but invisible footprints; hiding my scent as best I could. For the time being I staked my tent, unrolled my bed, drank some lukewarm water I'd poured twelve hours ago, and ate my worst meal yet: A packet of trail mix with moulding raisins. Here's to discovery, money, and survival, I toasted to myself, thinking the whole ordeal a bit surreal. Isolation would probably do me in before termination. I could feel it tugging at my loose ends.

Sleeping in my new tent, even closer to the elements than before, wasn't fun. The supposedly high-tech rock hut had insulated walls, at least, that weren't thin nylon and mesh, and I didn't have to wake myself every few hours out of sheer discomfort (and a nagging fear

that I'd freeze without realising it). My watch stayed glued to my wrist, vibrating at regular intervals. For the first day and the entire coming week, I dreamt in bursts of blood like some prey animal dangling off a precipice. For what it was worth, at least the sleeping bag did me well. They'd given me one that managed about ten degrees lower than the average nighttime temperature *and* fit my proportions well— not long enough to freeze my legs, but not short enough for my back to break. Little pleasures like that kept me 'living' for the time being.

The first morning, barely present, I poured myself a cup of water to wash the sticky ice-cold film from my lips and sprinkled some freeze-dried banana chunks into my palm. 11:30 PM. I'd have to move soon, lest all hell break loose and my schedule crawl back. The quick hike around the bend only took about an hour. Already on the cusp of spring, temperatures had straightened their bowed heads and begun to rise with the sun, sometimes above zero in the morning. I didn't mind cleaning my boots on the light sprinkles of snow and rock that passed me by.

Approaching my subject's cave warned me more in image than sense. As I came near enough to see the shadow cast by its black, empty mouth, I watched as the scrubby bushes slowly fell away. In their stead, something I'd only seen from my camera; an almost-decorative spread of old twigs, branches, and dead leaves that now clearly formed a path to the entrance.

It was jarring, being unable to check my camera footage in the morning, relying on intuition and so-far unshakeable schedules for my safety. But I liked it in some self-sacrificial way. Dying a sorry sage on this mountain was better than most else. Taking care to leave light footprints in the snow, I hiked all the way to its front door. My scent wouldn't linger here, hidden under layers of musk I could now clearly smell, and my presence was hardly felt by the world, so all-eclipsing around me, titanous in its sublime state of being. My eyes strained

deeper into the cave. I was convinced that the creature had left, as per my schedule and the obvious fact of not having been found, but paranoia kept me back.

Where was my headlamp? I had headlamps... A headlamp on my... Head. Somewhere. Where? My head. Stupid. Thoughts ran in circles until, like the first shock I'd gotten during the creature's visit, they disappeared altogether. Flipping on my headlamp proved difficult with all my shaking, gloved hands burning from the thaw of anticipation—but I managed. It took three straight minutes.

The cave's interior was larger than its entrance betrayed. Cut raggedly into the mountainside, like someone had bitten a chunk out of the rock and hurled it somewhere below, I noted some degree of flatness in the walls and ceiling, along with the powdery, pungent, almost burnt smell that suffused the air. It wasn't from ash. That I could tell. It was very much a byproduct of secretion. Such a substance would likely be concentrated in (and released from) glands underneath my subject's mass of fur. Adult male deer had the same, and lemurs too, all to attract mates. As per previous observation, though, this creature was the only one of its kind for miles around, which made its marker useless other than to mask my intrusion.

Covering my nose and mouth with the tip of my parka collar, I moved on. The interior was large enough in diameter to fit four human wingspans, but austere decorated. There was an obvious sense of deliberation, rugged but not unlived-in—like some property you'd sell to a rich person for a night, advertising the 'mountain experience'. Bare in the civilised sense of the word. The sporadically scattered stacks of rocks forming a circle around the cave's interior were especially intriguing. They must have been rolled in with effort.

I found no columns or buttresses protruding from the floors and ceilings; only snapped-off stumps. Several low rocks sat in one corner, one of which was wide, hollowed

out, and full of ash. The others surrounded it, almost shaped like tree trunks. Walking forward, I felt something crack underfoot. A jarring, echoing snap of bone split through hollow space, and my swear echoed too: *Fuck*. Human noises were unfit for the small world I had intruded on. The small home. I had to stop myself from praying for forgiveness.

Little bits of skulls, femurs, and old pelts littered the ground. Recalling the hunter's myths, his accusations of murder, I took a closer look at their composition and snapped some reference shots. Strangely enough, no bone belonged to a human. They were all too small, too delicate, or obviously from something else -- which, following that same logical track, made me wonder about the "missing villagers". Next time, I hoped to discuss such matters with the village head; whoever that was.. And if they existed in the first place. Given the chance (and given that my superiors knew nothing of it), I decided I would promote the creature's innocence on my next trip down. Oh, but my company -- they'd told me not to meddle. I wasn't a detective, anyway. I was a researcher, forged from objectivity and distilled from sociocultural starstuff.

Larger bones leaned against the back walls, some of which looked decorative— and others, clearly in the process of being worked, were sharpened like weapons beside a makeshift whetstone. I'd never seen the creature use tools, even rudimentary ones, but I did recall my briefing papers mentioning something of the sort. It could be, I reckoned while thumbing what looked like an arrowhead, that these weren't for hunting... But what else, then?

My fingers ran over the points, bathed in the same musky deer-scent as the cave itself, and I was kept there until better judgement took hold. If my subject noticed anything out of place or missing, it would grow distressed. It was intelligent enough for that, at least. From a

purely scientific standpoint, stealing was bad. I hadn't yet the morals to approach my situation any other way, and I definitely hadn't the appreciation of life.

Besides the bones, ashen stone and deliberately-engineered rocks surrounding it, a few other things caught my eye. As I scoped out some measurements, going by feet (22 by 25...?) and searching for an inconspicuous place to plant my equipment, I found what looked like a storage compartment carved into the rock. Huh. Looked just like the one in my own rock-hut, with a seam in the ground with a slightly raised portion for handling. Carefully, I opened the compartment, resting the lid against a wall. What I found, I half-expected, but eating the fruits of thought was different than letting them rot in my mind.

Fruits of thought, metaphorically, weren't too far off. Wilting flowers and stems slipped through my fingers, coloured in monochrome, so caked with dirt and dust that they were barely pretty anymore; barely there. This discovery brought to me the same uncomfortable light that I'd felt after hearing it scream— an anomalous behaviour's product, unscientific at first look but clearly *there*. Tenderness made solid. Out of respect, as if the flowers were real dead bodies, I closed the compartment and placed my remote camera behind a rock. If the creature found it, oh well. The thing looked just like a pebble, and it would shatter like one too. I wasn't worried about my tech's fate so much as I was worried about mine... And that which belonged to the strange creature. Had I started caring about it?

I held that thought and shone my headlamp over the walls, catching flashes of colour around me. They danced like hallucinations, half tricks of the light and half obviously real, and as my parka collar slipped from my chin, I almost wanted the cold to freeze me solid. It was difficult to get a clear view against my blinding headlight, but I managed. The stiller I stood, the better my eyes focused. Those were...

Cave paintings...? Cave paintings. Dancing, organic lines smeared in bone black, calcite, and stark red stains that tugged at the heels of Titian. Art wasn't my strong suit. Neither was anthropology. But I knew what each line represented in a primal sense. The overarching white rays were the sun, the jagged shapes mountains, and the vibrant blood-spatters prey.

I snapped photos of each, reminding myself to investigate where they'd obtained the minerals to make paint as my flashes lit up the wall. This was the creature's life, not their leisure trip. Not their scientific gig. Once again, I had raised the debasement of mankind to new heights. Craven enough to intrude only in its absence, but bold enough to even try in the first place, I stood at an awkward middling space. When my photos turned out terribly, I decided I'd bow out for the day. How would I feel if someone strange and small rifled through *my* things? Well, no. That comparison made no sense. Circling back, this wasn't the home of someone I respected. No need to feel bad about it. Rooms with tables, chairs, the usual things... Now, those were real. Humanising animals never went well, and so long as this one didn't catch on, my breach of privacy was justified. Probably.

Stuffing the camera back into my bag, another suspicious noise caught me off-guard. It was a clinking this time, not the careless snap of bone. I lowered my headlamp and scanned the cave floor for whatever had tinkled, fallen, moved, but eventually gave up looking. Time was a-ticking, and I was numb at all my outer points. Too buoyed with fear, residual excitement, and hunger to consider much else, I floated over the divorce I had yet again signed between myself and this creature. Biological revelation hung over my head, the mountains, and the far-off village like a carrot just out of reach.

Hopefully all would go well. Hopefully the camera would catch what I wanted it to. More evidence of work. More evidence for pay. More evidence that my subject existed in

some capacity and I wasn't driving myself insane. The only difficult part, now, would be avoiding the footage with its face. "No direct observation", I remembered— but direct observation was inevitable in the sense that up-close was 'direct'. This made no sense.

Oxymorons. Difficult jobs. Clink, clink, clink; the lack thereof. Someone would kill to be in my position, especially given the current state of the world. Scientists never had jobs. They never had stable incomes, they never had anything to their names. Somehow, by a trick of fate, I was special. Before I went on, I promised that if I survived the coming week (and the coming months), I would keep all the best data for myself. Who worked on it? Who thawed their frozen limbs and cast away civility to get stupid notes on a stupid animal? Not my company. Not Felina in her cubicle. An about-to-burst sourness nearly dissolved my head until I watered it down with everything else.

I returned to my tent at around 4 AM. After an hour and a half spent telling myself, "two more minutes", cold coffee and leftover freeze-dried banana pieces greeted me. There was snowfall on the horizon. I could sense it. The sky clouded over with steely grey tulle, and I wrapped myself in an emergency blanket once I'd zipped the tent shut and activated a pack of hand warmers. My foldable, wireless monitor, hooked up to the planted camera, sat beside me like an old friend. Rifling through my hiking backpack one last time before I called it a day, I found nearly everything I'd left with— besides the camera, of course. And besides the..? Besides the... Oh, no. *No*.

My good luck bracelet was missing. The dull green one, sloppily strung along but somehow invincible. First of all, I'd sent the poor thing to its death. Second of all, the poor thing was shiny and stunk of me, which meant I'd sent *myself* to my death.

I must have dropped it in the cave. That was the obvious answer. Or, for optimism's sake, in the snow. Picking up with my thoughts, what was a light tap-tap of snow surged into

a raging blizzard that teased the walls of my tent. Nature mocked me. While my mind raced, body straining to not run outside and go looking, the sky blushed white with laughter. Panic was scientifically explainable, but unpleasant nonetheless. I only felt calmer once I accepted the futility of my position— and the rational skeleton of it all, adrenaline increasing my heart rate through the sympathetic nerve. My heart wanted me to run and scream. My heart wanted something fixed, that I was certain of...

But I had the pressing sense that there were worse monsters to fear. I'd confirmed this one's innocence, after all. For the time being, the futile time, I nibbled away at the last of my banana chunks like a starving macaque. Life went on.

That night, the temperatures skyrocketed to barely sub-zero; not even cold enough to sustain icicles. It hadn't snowed since the last storm. Greenhouse gases took a great toll on the world, these mountains especially. That was why disciples of science preceded those of magic. Places like the platform on which my tent rested were dangerous, always at risk of crumbling away and joining the countless other bodies of dead stars, dead fish, dead starfish.

I knew by the way my thoughts spun in circles that I was sleeping, but these circular things, like plasmids, took up too much real estate. Real estate. Back in the day, we lived on a small strip of road with flat, green-brown fields and muted roofs. Ours was muddy green as if to camouflage. Of course, we didn't last long there. Someone bought up the land and we left, carrying invisible strips of mould and mildew on our clothes that new neighbours could smell. I was never too close with my parents. I think they wanted me to work.

Their faces appeared in my sleep, hence me breaking my promise of avoiding them. Strangest thing was, instead of regular human faces, they sported gas masks and nothing, really, underneath. Just a fog that had already broken through. This nebulous, greyish, maybe

medicinal substance. My nostrils burnt with the minty camphor of it. And I laid out priorities, job histories, wants and wishes and dutiful neurotransmitters.

Working had become a bit like a part of me. Well, not a bit. Entirely. Science, I conceded, was Stockholm syndrome. They had to let me go, or I would let myself go. I would let myself slip and go rogue, more like. An interwoven mat chafed my feet in sleep, not actuality. Another concession I made was that civilization would one day let me go too. I had a mirror somewhere. I poked around in my pockets for a mirror. Mirror.

Cold air rushed into my newborn lungs, all cleared, and it was morning again.

I'd mostly forgotten my dream apart from useless words, themes, and details. Worse had gotten past before—and this, in effect, was a success. My earlier worries about the green bracelet seemed very far away. Very minor, very stupid. The domesticity of wiping sleep from my eyes and repeating the same routine I had practised yesterday was good. Solitaire received its flowers again, again, and again.

At approximately 7:00 A.M, over a day after my last trip outside, I filled in the blanks of my latest research log and checked my remote camera footage. No close-up details were available. The creature stayed in a far corner, just a sliver out of range, but I was able to discern when it left and how it went about living, eating, et cetera. My logs consisted of motion-blurred sketches, some pressing questions that I shouldn't have asked (Who kills the villagers? Is inaction ethical? What does anyone want, really? Where's my stupid bracelet?), and qualitative observations scratched so vigorously into the paper that they bled.

Later, I tested the zipper on the tent to ensure it hadn't frozen or jammed or anything unfortunate like that. If it had, my pocket knife would come out, as well the greasy stuff in a red twist-off container that had somehow materialised amongst my rations. I planned for

terror that way, always preemptive and careful. When the zipper went down just fine, my head peeked out at the sunrise. It was a matted, wild head; someone might have mistaken me for an animal myself.

The air was crisp and cold and smelled of wet earth. I let my guard fall at the purity and breathed in. Someone, somewhere, would pay thousands for this so-called authentic mountain retreat, so long as they didn't have to piss behind rocks like me.

Some ways away from the tent, a green speck shone. I rubbed my eyes. Shining green things didn't appear naturally— well, they did, but not by... Cropping up on mountains. That was unscientific. Not bothering to throw on my parka, I half-walked, half-scrampered over the rock, then grabbed it like a greedy little thing. It was, as I'd suspected, my bracelet. I swore I hadn't dropped it there.

But I paused. New knowledge conflated with old. From there I concluded that the noise-apart-from-bone in the cave was the sound of me leaving an unseen bracelet behind, thus its being here was effectively impossible unless someone or something did me a service?

The creature never visited this part of the mountain, though it was very able. I'd gone a bit soft (and embraced this softness, too) after seeing its paintings; intimate life; daily romps; all-too-familiar pain. Scurrying around like mad was silly. Stupid, even— still clinging onto the constraints of my job as if they even mattered— and what, had my subject ever sent me off to dangerous places? Had it ever hurt me?

Had *they* ever hurt me? Or anyone else, as proven by observation?

'They' were de-objectified for the moment. Perhaps for the experiment. The new experiment, that was. I sat in my cramped tent, fiddling with my bracelet, which reeked of musk and sweat, and considered some way I could change my thoughts; the mat of priorities

I'd dreamt about earlier. Greatness, that was one priority. But more so a lofty dream. Survival... That was another. I also prioritised complaining, complaining about my frozen limbs and my muscle aches and the bare sustenance that banana-flavoured food gave me. They'd trained me for what? Months. My hands ripped at the bracelet nervously until it finally gave, bouncing all over the tent floor.

My employers said a study would take place, but not much more than that. Who was studying who? Was there any merit in hiding information from their head researcher? I ripped at the redactions on my briefing form. Kindness beat like a heart in vitro. I knew the implications of jumping to conclusions and asking unanswerable questions, but I also knew the unfairness around me, and I couldn't fathom why I hadn't done something sooner. Acted out wildly. Went on a murderous romp.

The only logical conclusion was that the creature had left its comforts to deliver this bracelet. This offering, now lying dead around me, meant peace. I gathered the beads one by one by, all the while remembering the hunter's stories. He wanted to kill it— them. My company wanted to exploit it— them. My eyes stung with the totality of this all.

What I eventually came around to doing, instead of losing my mind in the mats that plagued my hair, was the new experiment: A sort of going rogue. Shovelling bits of no-name 'banana meal' into my mouth, I tore a page from my notebook. Explaining this deviation from standard procedure would likely if not definitely put me in danger with management. Not with the creature, who I'd convinced myself was safe so long as our eyes never met. I had more to worry about than that.

My company sent me up here with two colours of pens. I made do with the sad blacks and blues and drew a crude imitation of what I'd photographed in the creature's cave— but of course, my deliberate strokes weren't half as beautiful as the wild paw-swipes and

claw-prints. In the unlikely event that they received and/or understood my drawings, I included an awkward rendition of their furry back and myself, standing far off on the edge of a cliff. Not looking to jump down, just thinking, as I knew they did.

The land outside my tent was mostly barren, excepting some dead brittle tendrils of organic matter. I collected them and weaved a little crown-thing, but my numb hands ruined its charm. The next best alternative, I surmised, would be a heat pack, so I folded the torn page all around it like gift-wrap. Soon I'd visit the village again. And I'd discuss matters of the creature with the hunter again, but seriously. Hand him clear evidence of their goodness. I would also ask whether anyone had *seen* their face in the flesh, or whether the myths and legends were all from delusional survivors.

Experiments helped people, primarily. Science was humanistic, primarily. At least in the way humans conducted it. If I were to be great, and if I were to 'disprove' the notion of monstrosity, I would do it through an experiment. Procedures watered the soul, results fertilised the soul, and the soul was the sun shining down upon itself. So my mind was possibly going. It was definitely going. But I didn't have the time to panic in that regard.

The first stage of my new experiments, dubbed "Trial" in a penned-off section of my notebook, began smoothly. I deposited the crown and surrounding art near the creature's cave, but not inside so as to respect their privacy. Initially I considered taking back the camera, but some still-perverse part of me needed the information; the data that would bring me as close as possible to their life. While waiting for a response to my gift, I browsed through time-lapses and blurry photographs of... Mostly fur. On the odd occasions that fur or dust didn't block the small, camouflaged lens, there wasn't much to see. Just the creature's hunched form gnawing at water shrews or snakes or the remaining bits of their caught stag.

Only four days in did the increasing body of observations and video recordings get interesting, to the eventual point where I sectioned off around twenty pages in my notebook for behavioural and physical observation; niche bits like “will not excrete indoors” and “fur slightly matted on the leftmost side”. Although the camera never came into view of the creature’s face, they would sometimes drop bones and dead bundles of grass before it. I initially assumed these actions had no relation to the camera itself (correlation does not equal causation, as science decreed), but time told a different story. It seemed as if they knew they were being watched, delusion and confirmation bias aside, placing objects in front of the device to either obscure my vision or make a statement. Just like me. I put duct tape over my laptop cameras. Oh, smart thing. Smart friend.

My first successful exchange came shortly before this realisation. Two days after I’d left the gifts, which was holistically four days into the camping trip (and three until I needed to restock provisions), another object made itself apparent outside the tent. The act of poking around, hoping and praying for any signs at all, bore fruit one morning. And I barely had to take a step outside, because jutting obviously from a nearby snowpile was an animal hide pocket. Tannin..? What trees were there to tan hide, and with what tools did they do so? The questions gave me the impression that I hadn’t seen the half of their skill set; an honest brag on their part.

Upon opening the hide pocket, which stunk badly, I found an assortment of red rocks and smaller, uncured scraps of animal skin that had already shrivelled up like prunes. They were frozen stiff, purple-brown like beef jerky. If I hadn’t been over the moon, this would have come off as a disgusting gift. But it wasn’t disgusting in any true sense of the word. The human sense of the word, and the world as a whole, tended to a rigid minority.

My hands took up the pocket gently, as if it were an injured bird. It was open, missing a flap, which I resolved to fix. I saw the creature's gift as an offering of friendship this time, now that our peace had been settled. Another major achievement, not in terms of peace but settling with myself, was the mere fact of feeling better. Feeling my heartbeat slow, pulse stagnate, fingers stop their nervous dances. Only a few days ago— was it a few, now?— I'd been so worried that the creature would see me, eat me, take me even, but I was now acutely unbothered. Radical scientists did things like these. Jane Goodall, two centuries ago, lived with chimpanzees and became a sort of messiah. David Attenborough, a similarly well-received historical figure, travelled all about taking photographs like I did. They hadn't ever gone insane. In fact, their footage looked saner than most else from their respective decades. Finding peace with the incomprehensible natural world was the only way to first understand, then collect. So I understood that I had to understand.

We went back and forth for the remaining days. It was a bit like a game, the creature finding new trinkets to give (whose meanings I tried and failed to analyse) and me considering what modern things I might deliver in return. By the end I'd received seven scraps of jerky, skin, whatever its purpose was, sixteen rocks of assorted colours and shapes, ten bones engraved with purposeful but rudimentary marks, and one small, rough stone with red and white bands. I logged these things in my journal, adding annotations like, "shrew skull", "femur", and "possibly rhyolite".

More than the research-related merit, it was also nice to be cared for. Weeks earlier, I decided that no one would find my dead body on the mountain— but at that time, I was also convinced the creature was my enemy. Or at least an object to be observed and feared all at once, like an angel.

As for cognitive analysis, they seemed strikingly intelligent, even more so than my briefing papers had let on. Not even the early hominins had much luck carving, tanning, exercising feats of dexterity and above all appreciating beauty, thus the creature was blessed with some kind of evolutionary boon adjacent to Homo Sapiens; four legs, common predator morphology, and paws (hands?) nimble enough to take on crafts like pocket-making. Some sort of adhesive had been used to secure the pocket, although I wasn't sure of its nature. Anyway, a feat. A real feat. What a shame we would never see each other properly, never getting as close as Goodall and her chimpanzees so that I could learn firsthand why they went on walks and etched out their surroundings. And, of course, screamed into the mountain-fog, a sound that hadn't come around since my relocation. I briefly wondered why that was before deciding to part from old perversions.

We'd gotten up close and personal, to a permissible extent that kept my contract intact. I'd never gotten up close and personal with a *person* before. Was that sad? Probably. Regardless, I decided it was high time to give the creature a name and stop calling the poor thing "creature". Felt reductive, prejudiced and schematic, like concept art of a character that was nothing more than 2-D; not fleshed-out in the sense that audiences for years to come would revel, but instead just... There. There to make concrete an archetype.

So I named them Ellis. Ellis sounded gender-neutral enough. Ellis was also objectively normal. Nothing crazy, fantasy-related, the usual fare for monsters. By giving them such a name, I found that power and agency had lent their memory agency. They could be kind if they wished. They most definitely had the power to do so.

Now, the hunter's stories seemed impossible. In no way could such an empathetic creature be a demon, a byproduct of natural revenge, nor could they inspire hate without some *very* deep-rooted misunderstandings.

After precisely one week I made my descent, impressive footage, extensive notes, and gift-swollen hiking pack in tow. The tent folded up well— how great was technology these days, when they really tried?— and I managed to shove the less important business into a compacted lump. With my missing rations, everything was a whole lot lighter. Like the burden of weight had dropped for the burden of truth.

My going plan, before the new experiment recommenced, was to visit the village instead of my rock-hut, which interested me little besides the banana-adjacent food. Some optimistic part of me still wanted to recount my experiences to the hunter. He hated the creature, but that was because he hated their assault on his people, which I could understand. Perfectly sensible. Overturning that assault would thus, logically, change his mind and stop his fellow villagers from launching attacks... Or whatever they had planned.

Felina discouraged meddling. My company discouraged meddling. Despite these strong demotivators I only found myself weakly demotivated, to say the most. Felina and her representative conglomerate were less real than the situation at hand. Disembodied voices from some useless comms device. If I delayed my next communication for a week, I'd only have to find an excuse. They wouldn't know anything of it, and they wouldn't fire me.

Empowered with youthful vigour, something I hadn't felt in a damn long time, I began my next great journey. My wristwatch alerted me of my low resting heart rate. Mountaineering had gotten much easier, and I could now travel the rocks and snow like a goat. I ensured that I left while the creature was out hunting. I'd be back soon anyway, if all went well.

The mountains struck upward like towers, lightning-bolts made solid and thick, against a clear sky blushing cold from top to bottom. From the position I assumed halfway

down, I could see the farms cascading below. There was an obvious line between the two realms. One which most (except for good old me) respected not to cross.

I crossed it anyway, and found myself in the village without much fanfare. Unlike my previous two visits, almost no one ‘welcomed’ me; that was, glowered at me. The main path and its surrounding homes were dead silent, coloured doors shut, some padlocked or blocked with wooden bars. Upon walking further, I met my first trace of civilization— a young man with an armful of freshly-sprouted green leaves glancing back and forth as if he were being followed. Busy but eager to dodge my questions, he mentioned how spring was on the horizon and how the early-cold plants had already started coming up. Best to eat them now. I then said that wasn’t at all related to my inquiry. *He* said he was deaf in one ear and asked me to repeat it louder. I yelled. He ran.

As I went further down the way, my chest grew tight as if the muscle inside was strangling itself. Every next breath made a strange noise, like the crackle of rice in maracas. High altitude de-acclimatization syndrome? Oh, *come on*. I’d trained for things like this. Clapping a hand over my mouth to contain the acid, I stumbled on for as long as I could, reminding myself that in just a few hundred metres, I’d be safe.

My hunter friend— acquaintance, really— was the best bet for inquiry. Another supposed attack? Another useless myth? Swallowing my scepticism, I knocked on his door. He received me kindly but warily. As usual, he offered bitter tea and some fishy provisions for the return journey, at which point he mentioned my unkemptness. I’d been camping, I explained, to a reply along the lines of, “You barely look like a man.”

My hair..? It gave me warmth. It sustained me. That was indeed a subhuman consideration, but I no longer felt self-conscious about my proximity to the wild. If the

creature could appear so savage and prove creative, intelligent, even kind, then I could too. I explained this to him, but he seemed sceptical. Asked me if I was sick.

I took him seriously at first. Replied that, apart from feeling under the weather, my vital signs weren't in the death zone. According to my watch. He felt my forehead, an action that I did not appreciate nor consent to, and warned me of fever. At that point, I realised what he was letting on to. Poor man thought I'd gone insane from isolation.

He broached the idea gently and proposed I stay a bit longer than one night. Travelling alone was unsafe, considering the recent events. What recent events? Those he did not disclose, but the hollow look in his eyes gave me the impression of another 'demon attack'. He and some others would deal with it once and for all, apparently, next week on the full moon. They would drive a stake through its heart and let its head make the rounds so everyone else could throw rocks at it. It, not them. I sought to correct his misinformation:

Before anything else, your so-called demon is sentient and in fact very sensitive. They (Ellis) are a predator, yes, but not of humans. I'm not clear on the biology behind why they shouldn't be seen, but reports of so-called 'insanity' after sightings were likely not the product of an intentional attack. Any actual disappearances are not at all related to them. See, I've got photographic proof here...

Thankfully, I'd brought along all my equipment. The small screen connected to the remote camera was non-operational at such distances, but the proper camera worked just fine. I watched the hunter's eyes narrow; his eyebrows converge; his upper lip curl the slightest bit; and felt as if this might have been a bad idea. I'd dealt with evidence-averse people before. Back at the start of my contract, all the locals living near stormwatching sites were vehemently against evacuating. I dragged them all by their tails anyway.

The hunter, though, was a bit of a tough case. He snapped back bitterly, picking apart my photographs. What about that blurry shape? A human bone I hadn't noticed? And you call that thing *Ellis*?! Regardless of what the evidence said, he admitted, the villagers would launch their attack as soon as the creature returned for a romp. Blindfolds had been prepared and spears had been sharpened. I noted the stupidity of fighting blindfolded, but he assured me that they were woven thinly, just enough to shroud the creature's eyes and face. Not their form. The hut suddenly fell out under my feet, revealing bubbles and tide pools that came undone to something even looser; something gaseous. Maybe a fever *was* brewing.

We argued about the creature and the village for some time. I forced him to continue as if I were fine, but my head had started to throb. Every few seconds, his face shifted in and out of focus. He made valid points, namely about my lack of historical and cultural knowledge compared to his, and I made less valid, but still crucial points. The creature and their strange appreciation for beauty, detail, and life were to the hunter and his crusade as a titan to a mortal. How could he stand against their gifts and stone tablets? He couldn't. And that was his problem. I bit my tongue to hold back a rising wave of nausea.

I also argued for my company, although I'd decided to temporarily excommunicate them from the new experiment. They would lose their minds if a valuable research subject suddenly up-and-died, and both myself and him would take the fall for it. Above the titans and the mortals was the conglomerate, or perhaps the driving force of the cosmos that brought such greed into existence— and from an ethical angle, the hunter would be no better than them if he engaged in useless destruction as my company did to the Northern mountains. On the topic of your good-for-nothing company, he retorted, but I stopped him there. My point had not yet been made.

I rambled on for some time, even after realising that I *had* begun to feel unwell, and sped up accordingly, launching into a long-winded rant of my experiences to date, handing him my precious journal but snatching it away when he turned a page. I watched myself from another body above myself, objectively of course, and wondered whether I'd gone insane and whether I should descend and stop it or not. The hunter began yelling, gesticulating wildly, at which point I raised my voice as well. Reverse altitude sickness, frustration, and the mounting nausea I'd tried to suppress thus far came bursting through the seawall that flowed into the now-gaseous floor. This wasn't scientific. This wasn't right.

When I spoke next, a spray of greenish, chunky (to my horror) liquid came spewing from my mouth. The hunter grew calmer, as if his suspicions had been substantiated by the act, but I apologised like mad. Never had I *ever* done this on a work contract. Never had I ever done this to begin with, actually. Huh. We all had our firsts.

He ushered me to a slumped armchair in a corner of the hut, all the while muttering about demons and their victims. How they destroyed love as a concept, then destroyed love as *your* concept and in turn, broke the mind. Demons were not friends. The smartest bits I mustered went along the lines of, "Following evidence and making friends aren't at all equivalent processes", and, "You don't know what you're talking about." He didn't. Hunting down a predatory animal (one with likely-opposable thumbs and preternatural intelligence, at that) was one, stupid... And two, counterproductive, given that they were not responsible whatsoever for their accused murders.

Still nauseous, I settled down. He would leave me to rest, he said. When I asked where he was headed, he only locked the door and bade me a good day. *Friend. Friend.*

For the next not-sure-how-long, I cradled my legs. An assembly line of shivers came over me— one, then another, cresting like dark waves as reasonable worries— what will

happen to my research? Will my company send emergency medical aid? Do I *need* emergency medical aid?— fell under. I'd dealt with fevers before. Usually repeated some simple set of words until I found the strength to either sleep or rise. *Friend. Friend.*

The hunter's hut was shabby, sure, but far from squalid. There was a meticulous order to everything. He seemed like the sort of man who believed that messiness yielded more work in the end. I fixed my gaze on the opposite wall, obviously scrubbed clean, and the loose wooden floor panels below me, coated in an indelible layer of black marks. Most fixable stains had been washed away. If I tried hard enough, I could imagine him kneeling with a rag in one hand and a bucket in the other. Clear as day. Clear as day, colours flashing in the corner of my eye. Maybe I was already dead.

Over at least five hours spent examining every nook and cranny of the one-room building, I found myself in an ironic position (a researcher's position) besides my delirium, the hazy sort which rests between life and vegetation; such a precarious, thin line to toe—treated nonetheless with the monk-like slowness of the ill; completely detached from the reality of the situation, allowing oneself to watch from above as a spectre would their haunt. I enjoyed my objective place. I also wondered why nobody ever wanted to study *people*. Psychologists did, technically speaking, but not in the right way.

In college I'd taken psychology classes, but the incongruence between measuring animal behaviour and human behaviour always struck me as more interesting than the content itself. Really, no differences existed. I logged the hunter's arriving and receding forms like tides, and only managed slight replies. Little cocks of my head, sips of water. My brain kept busy, circling around his behaviour as if death was no worry at all. I remember, sometimes, how I would mistake him for my subject. They didn't look alike, but I found within me the ability to create with my mind, and I created what was most comforting.

Ellis lumbered in on four legs, rising to two once they had cleared the doorway, shaking bits of matted fur and musk-drenched dirt on their entrance mat. They mimicked the cadence of their strange cliffside cry (which I sorely missed, because wasn't that just a perfect moment?) but adjusted its timbre and volume such that the rumbling noise came as a message of concern. Although my mind was lucid enough to recognize hallucinations as they appeared, I felt there was some truth there. Disappearing friends never boded well. For someone so lonely as them, the creature would surely go looking— not this far, no, but at least around my tent. I wondered whether they'd trashed the interior or snuffled through freeze-dried banana crumbs like a bear, and the idea was nice. Made me warm.

Of course, the hunter deserved his due diligence. Barely making ends meet to begin with, however folks met ends in this village, he did not toss me out nor rifle through my belongings. Instead, with the nervous precision of a parent, he coaxed stale bread and cold tea down my throat until I could string more than ten words together. He watched over me infrequently, but I would have lapsed into immediate delirium and death without him. His care was as much as I deserved. Maybe even too much, given how I'd acted earlier.

I woke up feeling more like myself at 1:25 A.M, according to my watch. Unsure of whether the hunter was asleep somewhere in the darkness, I shifted upright. My legs hit the ground clumsily, like a young colt's stick-legs, and a mass I assumed was my chest— torso, maybe, but arms were attached to it— swung around for balance. So much for all my pre-contract athletic training. Must have been two days at the least if my muscles were *this* weak.

Making some not-so-subtle noises to test the waters, it appeared that he was out. Otherwise he would have risen, grunted, and told me to leave if I felt well enough. I groped around on the ground for my equipment, panicked once I couldn't find it, and nearly fainted

from stress, but spying a backpack-shaped mound on his table averted the crisis. Upon approaching, carefully as I did with wild animals and their caves, I noticed yet another surprising thing; a small plastic-wrapped package beside my tossed belongings. That was new. *That* was also not made from materials readily available to rural hunters.

I handled the package as if it were a bomb. In the low light, I couldn't qualify my thoughts, but they ran along the lines of "company". After tearing layer upon layer of plastic and paper away, I had no need to qualify them anymore. If I'd been any more conscious, I might have started hyperventilating. Hands-off meant good. Hands-on meant problems. And deliveries were one half-step away from the latter.

By touch alone, I knew that this particular delivery was a new comms device. Small, round, and even darker than the night. String, looped through cardstock, dangled from its neck like a dog's leash. Why hadn't they given me medical attention? Drugs? As if *this* would help beyond the immediate science... Which I hadn't the means to pursue in my state, anyway. Discovering something great was good and well, but I liked myself. Well enough, anyway. Enough to not want death.

The device beeped red intermittently, and continued doing so until I caved and listened. Felina's voice crackled through the mini-microphone, much angrier than last time; palpable in the way she separated each word with a staccato intake of breath.

Unlike our previous exchange— unlike other exchanges with the hunter or the villagers, which I could not quote even moments after they occurred, she shot through my fever-addled brain clear as day. The despotic edge to her voice was sick. Bet she enjoyed bossing ecologists around. For the first time in a *stupidly* long stretch, I regretted signing a work contract. I'd waltzed into that one myself.

You are forbidden from meddling in the villagers' affairs. You are also forbidden from interacting with your subject in ways uncondusive to research, as well as deviating from your original instructions. Any further deviations will incur immediate investigation and prompt termination.

My fingers traced the smooth metal casing over the ridge where two curved sheets met. They shook. When muscles are primed to act, I thought offhandedly, they begin twitching. By way of adrenaline.

Once you have recovered, return to your original base of operations immediately. Or your remote base, so long as you take precautions to avoid observing the creature directly. From the little information we know, your recent actions have put both you and the project at risk. The villagers' organised violence is of NO concern to you. The being's mental, physical, and general state is of NO concern to you. Our unrelated projects in the Northern sector are, once again, irrelevant. This should serve as your final warning.

I tore the card to shreds, split the string with a dry snap, and left.

Please adhere to your code of conduct and reread it if necessary. Printed on the attached card is a QR array containing this code. It is imperative that you take time to recover. However, please resume work as soon as possible. You are, after all, taking unauthorised sick days on the clock.

I found myself outside, somewhere in this vastness; this endlessness of cresting soft hills. Detachment still kept me. Making the rational assumption that I hadn't yet recovered, I navigated my body as if it were a precious vessel. Turned the knobs, switched the pins. The air smelled cold and sweet, like menthol pulling at my skin, tugging hairs on end. I'd brought a shovel in my hurry, just in case a wild animal came at me, but the event was unlikely. Snow

leopards never descended, and as of two years ago there had been no recent sightings. Ellis probably killed most, given their place at the apex of the food chain...

But hey. What did all that matter? As if I'd wandered into some sort of brand new fairyland, I shuffled over the stubby, frost-tipped grasses in a daze. I went on, on, and on until the bottoms of my sock-covered feet grew numb and my breath no longer warmed me. Used to mountaintop routines, this lack of structure bore both panic and pride. Wild, animalistic pride, like I had intruded on an enemy's territory— and panic, reflected for similar reasons.

Reaching the top of a particularly large hill, I stood and admired my course; the moonlit roofs below, splatters of shingled paint on the ground, and the distant mountain-spears where I made camp all those weeks ago. Stilling my body in hopes that it would cure me, I stood there for some time until finally, defeatedly turning to generate some heat. Behind me was a balding field that ended at the treeline. A series of small, odd bumps reminiscent of burial mounds protruded every few metres. Frozen grass grew sparsely overtop; lush in some places, barely there in others. This looked man-made.

While squinting to get a sense of the field's length I noticed an object I hadn't caught yet, mistaken earlier for some unusual blade of grass or trick of light. It was a man's silhouette, given its height, and given the sharp point coming from his side, he held something shovel-adjacent. Under sickly lustre, his form raised the point. Lowered the point. Brought force to the half-frozen earth below and sent specks of moonlit dirt bursting asunder.

The terror that slowly came upon me, cheapening all scientific intrigue, called back to Ellis-researcher interaction #1. Similar coldness spread to my palms. Similar pain thumped against my ribcage. I dropped low to the ground so he would not see me. The man continued working at the earth below him, planting his shovel and heaving mounds of soil atop what was... Probably a hole? I crawled closer. Then closer, and even closer after that. Wind

slipped through the cracks between my ribs, bypassing my shirt entirely. A trickle of snot dribbled down my chin, and my back burned from the cold. Barely healthy, now back to square one. Great. From my new position, I could watch how his head dipped with exhaustion, yellow-white by the sallow moon. Dirt flew from his shovel as easily as sand.

The villagers around here had customs. They did. My briefing papers detailed some; how sometimes they would gather and dance, how they would care for goats, how they would treat friends like family and family like friends, how they fished in the streams, but— no, ahead of myself again— where did *burials* come in? They cremated their dead.

Rising to a half-lying, half-sitting position, sure that the man would not see me in his single-mindedness, I noticed my position between two mounds. Two mounds. The man dug away, transferring soil from one place to another. Two mounds. My head ached. If a body lay under each, which was likely, then some (if not most) surely belonged to...? The thought disturbed me, but my brain froze over before it could materialise. Worry kept me from intervening. Him and I, fighting with our shovels; he would win. I was sick and gone.

He left about thirty minutes afterwards. By some perfect stroke of luck, he'd bypassed my area entirely, instead choosing to head down a steeper part of the hill to the village. It was then that I made a mad dash for his newly-covered hole. It was overfilled but still fresh, not difficult to lift with a shovel, and adrenaline did wonders, because my shaking finally came to use. I found myself strong, capable, and more determined than ever.

Only when my hands finally gave up on me, shaking and numb, did I see what I'd hoped to see all along. I peered into the hole. In this hole sat a perfect, pearly-white set of human bones. Smiling to no one in particular, I thought bitterly, *told you so*. First and foremost, demons did not exist. Second, humans did.